



SANDY HUFFAKER For The Times

SAN DIEGO HOMECOMING

Emotion spills over as the USS Abraham Lincoln returns after a grueling 321 days away. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

RAID ON SKID ROW TARGETS DRUG DEALERS

LAPD and feds arrest 23 accused of selling illegal substances to homeless people.

By BRITTNY MEJIA AND RICHARD WINTON

Local and federal authorities said Thursday that more than two dozen people had been targeted for arrest in what they hailed as a sweeping operation against drug trafficking in the Skid Row area of Los Angeles.

First Assistant U.S. Atty. Bill Essayli said at a news conference that federal authorities had obtained 28 arrest warrants and 44 search warrants, and that 23 people were in custody as of Thursday afternoon. An FBI official said several others are still being sought for arrest.

"Individuals that we targeted in today's operations are selling drugs to the homeless people," Essayli said. "They're keeping the homeless addicted on hard drugs."

Essayli described the raids in a post on X as part of "Operation Save Skid Row," which he said also involved the Los Angeles Police Department, with more than 300 law enforcement officers participating from multiple federal agencies.

Thursday's raids stretched from Simi Valley to West Covina, targeting homes, a storefront downtown and numerous vehicles. According to criminal complaints filed by prosecutors, the accused dealers operated "stash pads" outside Skid Row and brought

[See Skid Row, A14]

Traffic cameras on PCH spot thousands of speeders

Tests show 100,000 violations over 9 days in Malibu. Some say tickets may not help.

By KAREN GARCIA

Pacific Coast Highway in Malibu is one of Southern California's most breath-taking drives — but also one of its deadliest.

The 21-mile stretch of winding coastal road has claimed more than 60 lives since 2010, and repeated efforts to improve safety have yielded mixed results.

Recently, the city turned to a new tactic: installing speed cameras along the highway. The early findings

have been dramatic.

Even though the cameras aren't yet issuing official tickets — the program must undergo a 60-day warning period in November — preliminary testing data captured approximately 100,000 speeding violations over the course of nine days last month.

The eye-popping number underscores what residents and city leaders say is a major speeding problem on the twisting roadway. There's hope the cameras could improve the situation, but also doubt that simply mailing out a slew of tickets will make a difference.

It also might offer a window into what other communities might see as speed cameras pop up around the

region. Los Angeles is expected to unveil a network of 125 cameras by the end of the month. Long Beach turned on its speed cameras Wednesday; there are a total of 16 camera locations with two more on the way.

From her office off Pacific Coast Highway and Carbon Beach, Felicia Daffara says she can hear the sirens as ambulances and sheriff's deputies race by when there's an accident in the area.

"The highway is dangerous right now," Daffara said.

The latest crash to generate headlines occurred the morning of Oct. 3, when authorities say a 16-year-old boy who appeared to be speeding struck a parked ve-

[See Cameras, A14]

A 'spider web' of brothels

Woman's call for help to the LAPD reveals a network operating in plain sight in the Valley

By Matthew Ormseth and Summer Lin

The woman didn't have much time to talk.

Speaking in Mandarin, she told a police dispatcher she was being held against her will in a Sun Valley home. She pleaded for officers to arrive quickly. If her captors caught her using a phone, she said, she'd be beaten.

The call for help in 2024 ended up pulling back the curtain on what a Los Angeles Police Department detective called a "spider web" of brothels that operated in plain sight throughout the San Fernando Valley. They were set up in nondescript suburban homes, often shielded by hedges or fences. Customers were told the operation prized discretion and safety.

In local government and law enforcement circles, the conversation around prostitution is often focused on infamous corridors such as Figueroa Street in South Los Angeles or Holt Boulevard in Pomona. Sex workers — some of them minors — walk the streets in revealing

clothes and high heels. These "blades" are often violent. Women are forcibly trafficked and raped. Customers are robbed. Rivalries between pimps can spill into gunfights.

But the network uncovered in the San Fernando Valley suggests another kind of prostitution is thriving behind closed doors.

The brothels were linked by what police described as a "call center." A client would send his age, nationality and location in a text message, and the call center operators would reply with an address, according to screenshots of the exchanges reviewed by The Times.

"We have many places to recommend you the best girls wherever you go, massage parlors, hotels, houses," an operator wrote to an undercover officer.

The network included at least 10 residential brothels in the San Fernando Valley, but its organizers were also linked to sex operations in the San Gabriel Valley, Orange County

[See Brothels, A7]

Scouting out scat near Joshua Tree

JOSHUA TREE, Calif. — Rescue dogs Merlin and Siska are readying for an important mission out in the Mojave Desert: find animal poop.

As the fall brings cooler weather, the pups will trot among the Joshua trees wearing orange vests, "doggles" to shield their eyes from the sun and booties to protect them from the prickly cholla cacti.

As wildlife biologist Christina Aiello searches for droppings of bighorn sheep, which are relatively abundant, the dog duo from Rogue Detection Teams will sniff out harder-to-find bobcat and mountain lion scat.

Here, conservationists are planning to build two wildlife crossings over State Route 62, which connects Los Angeles and Joshua

Dogs help gather data that could show wildlife crossings' effectiveness

By Noah Haggerty



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

HEATH SMITH and rescue dog Whisper demonstrate scat sample collection near Yucca Valley.

Tree National Park and is the site of hundreds of collisions between cars and wildlife every year.

Dead sheep and bears strewn along the pavement have disturbed local residents for years, but ecologists fear the road may also cause a much slower and quieter die-off, with mountain lions inbreeding as they are cut off from other lions.

As California works to build dozens more crossings like these around the state, researchers are hoping their animal poop surveys will show that the benefits of these crossings extend hundreds of miles beyond the roadway.

"The isolation, long-term, of those populations could mean that those wildlife species aren't viable into

[See Poop, A8]

Trump cracks down on elite study, work visas

Caltech, Microsoft, others are accused of overuse. Critics fear driving away talent.

By NILESH CHRISTOPHER, JAWEED KALEEM AND ANA CEBALLOS

The White House is expanding its campaign against international workers, targeting elite study and work visa holders with restrictions and a new investigation.

On Thursday, the Trump administration announced a probe into whether Stanford, Caltech, UC Davis and other universities across the country have been abusing a special visa used by international scholars and students to do research and work in the U.S. It is also suspending Microsoft, Adobe and six other tech companies from how they sponsor employees who are in the country under a highly skilled worker visa program.

The White House's concern is that schools and companies are too quick to bring in people from outside the U.S. The moves rattled the Silicon Valley executives and California educators who

see easy access to the smartest, hardest-working people in the world as one of America's greatest competitive advantages.

Vice President JD Vance said the universities being investigated are overusing J-1 visas to bring in students and researchers from abroad. The international scholars then take jobs and grants that could go to Americans.

"They are using these visas way too much," he said.

"They are using them to undercut the wages of American grad students and American researchers, and it simply has to stop."

Harvard, Yale, Brown, the University of Pittsburgh, Arizona State and MIT will also be investigated.

Labor Department Inspector General Anthony D'Esposito said subpoenas have been served and "nobody will be getting a free pass because their name is carved into an expensive building." Many universities have buildings named for foreign donors.

While most of the companies targeted for the tech visa restriction were Indian, Vance called out Microsoft.

"There's been no company, unfortunately, in the United States that has [See Visas, A12]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

AN AMTRAK Pacific Surfliner train runs along its low-lying tracks, close to the waves in San Clemente.

End of the line for a picturesque rail?

State will study how to move O.C. corridor threatened by rising seas away from coast.

By SUMMER LIN

The famed railroad line along the San Clemente coast has found itself on the endangered list amid a relentless assault from rising seas and punishing surf.

Transportation experts have long discussed the possibility of relocating the tracks in the area, but the California State Transportation Agency is expected to launch a study before year's end examining what would go into potentially moving the rail line, according to Darrell Johnson, chief executive of the Orange County Transportation Authority.

Johnson said the study would probably take at least several months to complete.

Transportation planners previously said it could cost more than \$5 billion to move

the tracks inland.

"It will be complex. It will be expensive. It will be long-term in nature," Johnson said of the study. "We're very pleased that later this year, the state of California is expected to kick off that study. We expect a lot of public engagement with that, and examining the options to frankly respond to these challenges that we're experiencing right now."

The stretch of track along the San Clemente shoreline has long offered picturesque views of sandy beaches and lapping ocean waves for passengers traveling between Los Angeles and San Diego. Commuters on the Amtrak Pacific Surfliner can enjoy a snack while taking in the sights, at a fraction of the cost of a plane ticket.

But over the years, landslides, coastal erosion and rockfalls have also threatened the stability of what's officially known as the LOS-SAN Corridor (short for Los Angeles-San Diego-San Luis Obispo) in parts of

[See Railroad, A7]

Eyes in the sky to reduce emissions

A second satellite is launched to double California's ability to detect methane gas leaks. **CLIMATE, A9**

A one-two punch to coastal areas

Tropical Storm Rachel and a Kelvin wave could bring rain and risk of flooding. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 86/66. **B5**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

County to review insurer's claims

Civil probe to determine whether the FAIR Plan broke consumer protection laws. **BUSINESS, A10**

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